



'can' and 'could'

Think of **Can** and **Could** as the "ability" brothers. They look similar, but they live in different time zones.

1. Ability and Possibility

- **Can:** Use this for things you are able to do **now** (the present).
 - *Example:* I **can** speak English.
- **Could:** Use this for things you were able to do **before** (the past).
 - *Example:* When I was five, I **could** ride a bike.

2. Requests and Permission

We use both to ask for things, but the "vibe" changes:

- **Can:** Friendly and informal. Use it with friends and family.
 - *Example:* **Can** I borrow your pen?
- **Could:** Polite and formal. Use it with strangers, bosses, or when you want to be extra nice.
 - *Example:* **Could** you please help me with this bag?

Quick Summary Table

Use Case	Present (Can)	Past (Could)
Ability	I can swim 1km.	I could swim 1km ten years ago.
Request	Can you open the door?	Could you open the door, please?
Negative	I cannot (can't) go.	I could not (couldn't) go.



Modal Verbs

Can or Could



ABILITY (Present)	I can speak five languages.
POSSIBILITY (Present)	Alcohol can cause cancer.
PERMISSION (Informal)	Can I use your computer, please?
REQUEST (Informal)	Can you hand me the pen?
OFFER (Help)	If they like, I can carry some bags for you.

ABILITY (Past)	He could play football well when he was a kid.
POSSIBILITY (Past)	A lot of crime could be prevented.
PERMISSION (Polite)	Could I please use your computer?
REQUEST (Polite)	Could you tell me where the post office is, please?
SUGGESTION	If you want, we could go out for dinner after school?

Exercise: Choose the Best Fit

Fill in the blanks with **can**, **can't**, **could**, or **couldn't**.

1. When I was a baby, I _____ speak, but I _____ cry very loudly!
2. I'm sorry, I _____ help you right now. I'm very busy.
3. _____ you pass me the salt, please? (Polite)
4. He is a genius; he _____ solve math problems in seconds.
5. Last night, the music was so loud that I _____ sleep.

Homework Assignment

Part A: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite these present-tense sentences into the **past**.

- *Example:* I can run fast. *I could run fast.*

1. Sarah can play the violin. _____
2. We can't find the keys. _____
3. Can you hear that noise? _____

Part B: Writing Practice

Write **three** sentences about things you **could** do when you were 10 years old that you **can't** (or don't) do now.

- *Example:* I could climb trees easily, but now I'm too tired!